NASM VIRTUAL COACHING SPECIALIST (VCS)

Chapter 9: Marketing Virtual Coaching

National Academy of Sports Medicine — Evidence-Based Telehealth Curriculum

Chapter 8Selling Virtual Coaching
Lesson 4Billing and Collecting Payment

Summary

Like any small business owner, a fitness professional who owns a virtual coaching business has roles and responsibilities that extend beyond developing programs and coaching clients, such as marketing their services and generating sales. Sales are vital to a company's success. Without sales, there is no revenue and without revenue, there is no company. While focusing on sales is often viewed with a negative connotation, it does not have to be. Ethical sales strategies and techniques are rooted in educating and helping others. It, ultimately, comes down to identifying potential clients' needs, offering solutions to those needs, and then asking them to make a financial commitment for those solutions. The aspects of running a business that can be automated should be, as automation frees up time to focus on areas of the business that cannot be and are vital to establishing authority, credibility, and authenticity in the market, such as content development, programming, and coaching and serving clients.

Marketing and sales processes can largely be automated and when combined with proper market segmentation, allows for personalized messaging delivered directly into the hands, and eyes, of the business's target audience. Automated sales workflows leveraging e-mail can be customized to not only deliver highly impactful content to potential clients but can also be used to contact existing customers about service add-ons and upgrades and re-engage former clients in an attempt to build another meaningful relationship. Please refer to the video below for a summary of the topics discussed within this chapter.



NASM VCS lecture CH8 00:07:03

Zote, J. (2020, August) 11 Free Email Marketing Tools to Save You Time and Money. Retrieved from https://sproutsocial.com/insights/free-email-marketing-tools/

Online Marketing Vehicles

After defining the customer avatar, the fitness professional is ready to determine the best online marketing vehicle for their business. Using information from the customer avatar can guide the fitness professional to the best marketing vehicle to reach the maximum number of potential clients. Online marketing vehicles include social media, email, and websites.



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Social Media

According to the Pew Research Center (2019), nearly 72% of all Americans use at least some form of social media (**Figure: Social Media**). With the volume of potential clients using social media, it is an integral part of marketing and should not be underestimated. Social media can be a great way to bring awareness to a fitness professional's services and even serve to drive business.



FigureSocial Media

Variation Among Social Media Platforms

Note that not all social media platforms serve the same audience. There are many social media options available for consumers and, as a result, it can be difficult to know where to start in order to reach the target audience. This is where knowing the customer avatar is critical. Different social media platforms tend to have different populations as their most frequent users.

According to recent statistics, the number one demographic for Facebook users worldwide are men and women ages 25 to 34 (Clement, 2020). Contrast that to the younger demographic, the top three social media platforms for users ages 13 to 17 are YouTube, Instagram, and Snapchat (**Figure: Social Media Users**). Knowing this information will inform fitness professionals about where to find their target audience and how to vary the messages accordingly.



FigureSocial Media Users

Email

Email marketing is a proven form of digital marketing. Potential clients who provide fitness professionals with their email have demonstrated some form of interest in the product or service. Some common opt-ins may include newsletter subscriptions, instructional e-books, or PDFs. The email content that is offered must be compelling enough for someone to provide their email address. This can prove to be difficult, as individuals are increasingly more protective over their personal information.

Website

Like a storefront, a website is often one of the first impressions potential customers receive about an online business. Many consumers make their purchasing decisions based on the clarity and structure of a business's website. There are numerous services available when deciding how to host a website. WordPress, Squarespace, and Wix are some of the more popular options. Here a couple of things to remember when potential customers go to a website:

1. **Is the website easy to navigate?**
2. **Is it clear what the company is selling?**
3. **Is there an evergreen or deadline offer clearly being displayed?**
4. **Are next steps to purchasing clear (i.e., scheduling an assessment or buying a program)?**

Online Advertising for Small Businesses

Online advertising can be an effective way to boost traffic to a website and increase the potential for conversion of **prospects** into paid customers. When it comes to online advertising, there are multiple digital platforms that can be used successfully.

Social Media Platforms

Social media platforms such as Instagram and Facebook offer paid advertising to small businesses. Using these platforms for advertising allows a fitness professional to target the demographic they are marketing to. For example, a paid advertisement can target Facebook users by geographic location, age, and even other Facebook pages liked.

Search and Review Platforms

Another way to advertise for a small business is by utilizing search platforms such as Google or user review sites like Yelp. These platforms are commonly used by consumers who are searching for a specific service or product. These platforms typically utilize a **pay-per-click model** of paid advertising. An advantage to using platforms of this type is that the user searching for the service is already at least somewhat interested.

Prospect

A person whom the business has identified as fitting their client criteria but has not yet provided their information.

Pay-per-click model

A model of digital marketing in which the advertiser pays a fee every time their ad is clicked.

Online Marketing Best Practices and Professionalism

To truly be a successful online marketer, a fitness professional must know more than the various digital marketing platforms. They must also have a strong knowledge of which methods are most effective. The following section will discuss and review those methods and provide specific examples of implementation strategies.

Search Engine Optimization

On any given day, there are over 2 million searches conducted on Google alone (Patel, 2019). This is why **search engine optimization**, or SEO, has become an important factor in marketing and searchability. SEO is a method of improving a website's ranking during **organic**, unpaid searches. Research shows the first five results on Google get 67% of the clicks (Patel, 2019). In such a noisy, online world, ranking high on the list of these searches is paramount. One of the best and most effective ways to increase SEO is by producing quality content. Items such as blog posts and e-books can organically drive people to the site, which will, in turn, increase overall ranking in the eyes of the search engine.

Engagement Methods for Digital Marketing

To produce engaging content, a fitness professional should view their actions strategically, rather than use a one-size-fits-all approach. When thinking about posting a piece of content, a marketer needs a system to determine the effectiveness of their post. The fitness professional must set clear metrics of success for their digital marketing efforts and campaigns. These metrics should align with their business goals. Fitness professionals can use analytics tools such as Google Analytics and Sprout Social to monitor what is and what is not working and know how to adjust accordingly.



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Search engine optimization

A method of improving a website's ranking during organic, unpaid searches.

Organic

Traffic to a website or account that is not paid for.

Chapter 9Marketing Virtual Coaching
Lesson 2Online Marketing Vehicles and Strategies

There are many methods for delivering online messages but most fall into one of the four quadrants of digital marketing. These quadrants include building authority, social proof, connection, and attention (**Figure: Four Quadrants of Digital Marketing**).



FigureFour Quadrants of Digital Market

Webinars

Webinars are one of the fastest-growing digital marketing methods. Webinars are live or prerecorded virtual conferences or presentations. Webinars can help establish fitness professionals as an authority in a specific topic or niche. For example, if a nutrition coach is well-versed in weight loss, he or she could host a webinar on the topic of intermittent fasting.

Webinar Structure

There are typically two types of webinars that can be run—paid and free. Although a paid webinar can make money, it can also potentially limit the number of people who are able to attend. On the other hand, hosting a webinar may aid in lead qualification as only the most serious potential clients will be interested in attending. One possible strategy when hosting webinars is to host it for a small fee and then reveal a **back-end offer** near the end of the webinar. That offer could be a bit more exclusive for clients who are interested in learning more about the topic or possibly purchasing a higher-end service. Using that same example of the nutrition coach, a potential strategy could be to offer a nutrition consultation or a meal plan to anyone who attended the webinar. Web-based services like Zoom and Webinar Ninja allow any fitness professional to easily host a webinar.



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Back-end offer

An additional offer to a customer who has already purchased a product or service from the business, also referred to as an upsell.

Social Media Posts

Because each social media platform caters to a different audience, it is wise to post on multiple platforms rather than posting on just one. Posting on multiple platforms has been shown to have a positive impact on brand loyalty (Çiçek & Erdoğmuş, 2012). Considering this, the question then becomes, “What to post?” Fitness professionals should consider the four digital marketing quadrants when determining what type of content to post (**Figure: Examples of Four Quadrants**).



FigureExamples of Four Quadrants

It is best practice to use messaging in each quadrant from time to time so that social media marketing efforts are well-rounded and, therefore, more effective.

Social Media Schedule

Developing a social media schedule is critical to maintaining consistency with posting. Posting consistently is difficult but it becomes more so when there is no plan in place. Software like Later or Sprout Social can also aid in developing a social media schedule. These resources can provide analytics, such as peak engagement times for various social media platforms, that will help the fitness professional develop a deeper understanding of their audience.

When developing a social media plan, there are several factors to consider:

1. Which days receive the highest engagement?
2. What type of content resonates most with the audience?
3. What events or deadlines are being marketed toward?



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Getting Technical

There are many ways for fitness professionals to drive organic traffic to their social media pages.

1. On Instagram, post stories of clients' successes (text message, videos, pics, etc.) and encourage them to share the post. In this scenario, the fitness professional not only reaches their audience but their client's network/audience as well.
2. On Facebook, Twitter, or Instagram, the fitness professional can tag larger fitness accounts in the posts. If the larger accounts repost it, the fitness professional's organic reach will increase.
3. Facebook Live and Instagram Live are popular tools used by fitness professionals. For example, collaborating with other fitness professionals in live Q&A sessions is a great way to drive traffic to social media pages or websites.

Email Campaigns

An email list is crucial for marketing to an already interested audience. Remember, a person who has willingly given their e-mail is already interested in a service, at least on some level, which makes them more likely to convert into clients. When considering which email service to use, the fitness professional should find one that is reliable and supports them in executing their marketing plan. Some of the most popular email marketing options include Mailchimp, Constant Contact, and ConvertKit.



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Creating an Email Opt-In



FigureEmail Opt-In

It is one thing to have an e-mail list, but it is another to actually grow it. This is where an **opt-in email** becomes useful. An opt-in is when a consumer provides their e-mail address, usually in exchange for some sort of free content. These opt-ins are often in the form of pop-ups that appear when a person navigates through a website. Some common opt-in offers include newsletter subscriptions, instructional e-books, PDFs, or free training programs.

The quality of the opt-in should be high. The key is to provide enough value for the potential customer, while also giving them some insight into what purchasing a service might be like. Here is an example of a potential e-mail opt-in (**Figure: Email Opt-In**). Once that person's email is collected, they become a subscriber and a welcome email is typically sent confirming their subscription and delivering the promised content. From that point on, the fitness professional should continue to deliver valuable information to their subscribers so that they feel connected and part of the online community.

Newsletters

Newsletters are a great way to keep an audience engaged. Think of a newsletter as an online newspaper for a business. It keeps customers, subscribers, and potential customers up to date with current business events. Newsletters are where many fitness professionals highlight clients and tell their subscribers about any upcoming specials or events. Typically, newsletters fall into the Connection category of the four quadrants of virtual marketing.



This Is Me/Shutterstock.com

Opt-in email

An option to join an e-mail list.

YouTube

With over 2 billion users worldwide, YouTube is one of the most popular forms of media for consumer video consumption. Many online fitness professionals have gained popularity by dedicating their time to developing a YouTube platform. Creating a YouTube channel is a great way for a fitness professional to build authority in their respective field. A study examining student engagement while watching videos showed that shorter videos are more engaging than longer videos (Guo et al., 2014, p. 49). The study recommended video segments shorter than 6 minutes. As people have access to more content, holding viewer attention becomes an ever-present challenge. One method is to select or create an engaging thumbnail for all YouTube videos. An engaging thumbnail helps a video stand out as people scroll through the numerous YouTube fitness videos available.



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Blogs

Blogs are one of the best ways to create authoritative content and drive traffic to a website. Additionally, traffic created from blogs helps improve website visibility, search engine ranking, and ultimately SEO.

Methods for Increasing Blog Visibility

In the early inception of blogging, visibility was a relatively easy thing to obtain. However, as more people have started blogging, visibility has become much harder to achieve. By some estimates, there are over 600 million blogs on the Internet today (Petrov, 2020). With the large number of blogs available, the question then becomes, “How does the fitness professional’s blog stand out?”



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Here are a few methods to gain greater visibility through blogging:

- **Consistency** – To gain a loyal audience, a blogger must post consistently. Try setting a blog-release schedule.
- **Timing** – Publish blog posts on high-traffic social media days. For example, releasing a blog on a Tuesday, normally a high-traffic day, will likely yield greater engagement than a blog posted on a Saturday.
- **Naming a Post** – All digital marketing vies for consumer attention. The title of a blog post is the first thing someone sees and will often determine whether they choose to read on. Titles that begin with the phrases “How to…” and “Here are 5 ways to” tend to get more traffic over other more general titles.
- **Collaborations –** Collaborating with other fitness professionals is a great way to increase the reach of a blog post. Interviews and guest posts are all methods that increase the shareability of a blog post. The post then gains exposure for not only the fitness professional’s followers but also to the followers of the other collaborator.

Proper Messaging

Messaging varies depending on the social media platform and on the message being delivered. Generally, it is important to keep messaging concise and direct. Whenever posting digital content, proper messaging and professionalism is crucial. This is true for both professional and personal social media accounts as a fitness professional is ultimately a direct representation of their business. Proper grammar, spelling, and punctuation should be used in all posts. Additionally, most posts should be done in an authoritative tone to convey the expertise of the fitness professional.

Proper Use of Visuals

As the use of social media and digital marketing has grown, it is more important now than ever for the fitness professional to incorporate quality visuals into their social media marketing. The standard has been raised as more people become adept at visuals and social media. Camera phones have made this easier. With most phones now equipped with high-quality cameras, it is often unnecessary to hire a photographer to take professional photos. In the past, the creation of graphics required expensive software with a steep learning curve. However, now there are many graphic software products available, such as Canva or PicMonkey that make it easier and more cost-effective (and in many cases free) to design and edit high-quality marketing material.



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In addition to the quality of the visuals, the formatting of video and pictures is also important. For example, consider recording an exercise video with the intent of posting it on multiple video media platforms. Shooting the video in portrait mode (vertical orientation) is great for posting on an Instagram feed but it is not the ideal camera orientation for posting videos on YouTube. Landscape mode (horizontal orientation) is the preferred method for posting videos on YouTube and Facebook (**Figure: Video Format**). Videos shot in portrait mode leave extra space in the margins of the video when viewed on a widescreen, which can be distracting to the viewer.



FigureVideo Format

Word-of-Mouth Marketing

Despite the advancements in technology and digital platforms, word-of-mouth marketing continues to be an incredibly effective form of marketing. According to research, 67% of consumers are based on word of mouth (Karlíček et al., 2010). As a fitness professional, developing trust and a strong referral network from current clients is a good way to grow a sustainable online business.

Referrals

Offering existing members some type of incentive may encourage referrals. Ideally, clients will refer potential customers regardless of an incentive, but offering one can certainly help. One way to incentivize referrals is to offer a gift card or credit to clients who refer new clients to a business. A potential benefit of offering gift cards, as opposed to discounting an existing client's service, is that money spent on gift cards could potentially be written off for tax purposes, depending on the business situation. Additionally, gift cards do not devalue the price of training options.



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Testimonials

Testimonials tap into a powerful, scientific marketing principle—the principle of social proof. The principle of social proof suggests that individuals observe and assume the behaviors and actions of others to determine what is correct or to find out what other people think is correct (Cialdini, 2006). If a potential customer sees that someone like them has had good results and a positive experience, they are more likely to choose that same service over another one.

Obtaining Testimonials

Both written and video testimonials are excellent pieces of marketing material. There is some debate over which method is more effective. Luckily, with transcription services readily available, obtaining both is easy and relatively inexpensive. One way to obtain both types is to record a video testimonial of a client's experience and then send the audio file to a transcription service to have it converted into written format.

When gathering testimonials from clients, fitness professionals should provide a guide to follow so results come out clean and succinct. This guide may include recommendations for talking points and sample questions. The following are examples of questions that may yield a strong testimonial:

1. **What was your experience when you first started working with (insert name of fitness professional and business)?**
2. **What was the biggest challenge you faced?**
3. **What is your experience like now?**
4. **What is your favorite thing about training with (insert name of business)?**

Questions like these create a story or a *hero's arch* for the client testimonial. These questions relate their struggles and connect their story to others and potential clients who will likely share some of the same challenges.

Helpful Hint

Not sure whether to have a client do a written or a video testimonial? Why not do both?

With online transcription services, fitness professionals can record the video and then send it to a transcription company to have it converted into text. Typically, these companies charge a per-minute fee, and, for a short video, it is a valuable time saver. Once the fitness professional has the transcription and video, they can easily post and share them on various platforms.

Merchandise

Merchandise is often an underrated marketing tool. Merchandise is anything that clients can use or wear that represents a brand. Merchandise transforms the client into a walking billboard. Examples of effective merchandise for fitness businesses include t-shirts, stickers, and protein shaker bottles. The key to any sort of merchandise is to make sure the brand is clear and visible. Merchandise can also be an effective way to increase client retention. For example, if a client reaches a certain weight-loss goal, a great strategy would be to send them a t-shirt for their success and have them post a picture of themselves wearing it. This not only increases client retention but also helps build social proof for the brand.

Chapter 9Marketing Virtual Coaching
Lesson 3Evaluating Marketing Efforts

Calculating Marketing ROI

Calculating marketing **Return On Investment (ROI)** is a method for determining the effectiveness of a marketing campaign. The simplest equation to calculating ROI is as follows (**Figure: Return on Investment**):



FigureReturn on Investment
Return on investment (ROI)

A performance measure used to evaluate the efficiency of an investment or compare the efficiency of a number of different investments.

For example, imagine a nutrition coach is running a marketing campaign to promote their one-on-one meal planning service. The marketing campaign costs $200 and they have seen a $1,000 increase in revenue for that service. To calculate the return on the campaign investment, the fitness professional would subtract the cost from the sales growth and then divide that number by the costs associated with their marketing campaign (**Figure: Example Return on Investment)**.



FigureExample Return on Investment

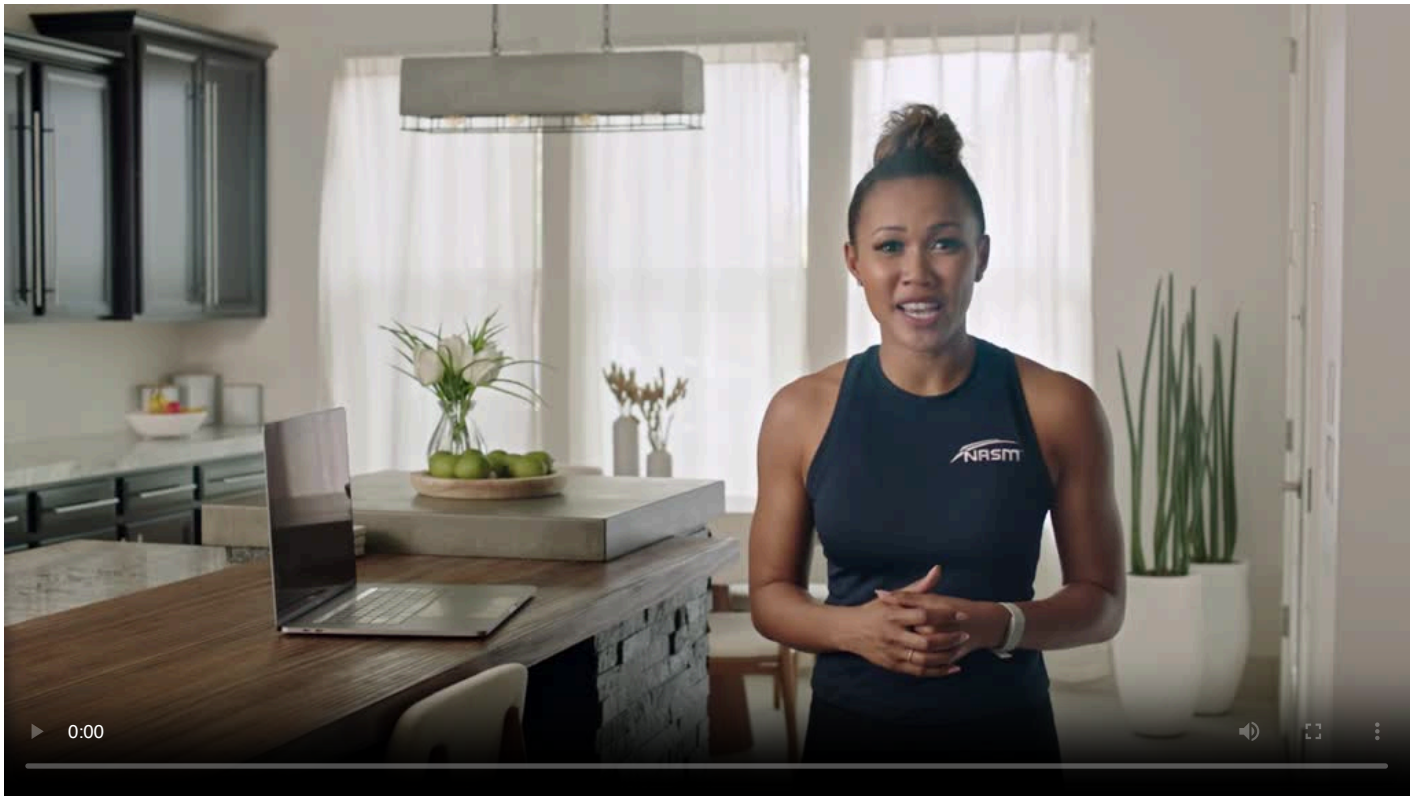
A positive return on investment signifies the returns were greater than the cost. A negative return on investment signifies the total costs associated with the marketing effort were greater than the returns.

Limitations of ROI

Not all marketing efforts are afforded an immediate return on investment. A fitness professional may host a webinar in June and then be contacted by a potential client in November for online training. It can often be difficult to pinpoint if that person came in because of a particular marketing effort. Always expecting immediate ROI from a marketing effort can also be problematic. Some marketing efforts need time to take effect. In general, while it is important to understand a campaign's ROI, it may be more ideal to have a long-term mindset when it comes to determining the true value and success of marketing efforts.

Summary

Marketing a virtual coaching business can seem like a complex and even daunting task. However, as a fitness professional, it is necessary to ensure the growth and success of an online business. This is especially true in the current landscape with demand for fitness services increasing and consumer desires and purchasing habits evolving. With proper marketing planning, knowledge of the various marketing vehicles, and an understanding of the best methods to increase visibility and engagement, a thriving and sustainable online fitness business is within reach. Please refer to the video below for a summary of the topics discussed within this chapter.



NASM vCS Lecture CH9
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